

ITEM WISE EDITORIAL ... 13th June, 2019



SHANGHAI COOPERATION ORGANISATION ... ADVANTAGES & CONTRADICTIONS



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EDITORIALS

... DISCUSSION

13th JUNE, 2019

7

Navigations in Bishkek

The regional aspirations of Central Asian countries contradict India's goals



A. P. J. ABUL KALAM

As the 19th Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) summit in Bishkek, Kyrgyzstan, India will have to navigate between two contradictory imperatives. While on the one hand it must act as a willing partner of regional cooperation led by China and Russia, on the other it must avoid being seen as a part of the 'anti-American gang'. It could all be well and good if India were to fight against terrorism through a body that includes states that pose the biggest threats to Indian security.

Trade and terrorism

In Bishkek, Russia and Central Asian countries are likely to express "fraternal support" for China in its escalating trade fight against the U.S. India is equally concerned about this trade war, but it is unclear whether it will join the others in slamming U.S. protectionism. New Delhi is seemingly confident of dealing with the U.S. without necessarily supporting China. For Chinese President Xi Jinping, whipping up anti-Americanism serves to divert off mounting opposition against his anti-corruption campaign and concentration of power. It is also notable that all SCO members having India as enthusiastic supporters of the Belt and Road Initiative (BRI).

The summit is likely to have a muted agenda. SCO Secretary General Vladimir Norov has hinted at adopting five elements to deepen multilateral cooperation and discussing non-conventional issues such as the fight against drug trafficking, cooperation in IT, environmental protection and biodiversity. Terrorism is likely to be approached from the angle of improving the situation in Afghanistan and not necessarily of curbing the terrorist elements emanating from Pakistan. China is sure to offer its experiences of dealing with counter-terrorism, and the deradicalisation measures it has taken in Xinjiang. China's achievement in expanding its high-speed rail network to revive Xinjiang's economy with economic and security implications for Russia. China has also enhanced its military presence capabilities to meet any potential crisis beyond its western frontiers.

Kyrgyzstan is the latest to create an



PM Modi and President Xi Jinping on the sidelines of the SCO in China in 2018.

international area-border trade centre in Alai district bordering China. If the regional countries switch to adopting the Chinese railway track gauge of 1,435 mm, then China will be successful in uniting Eurasia to challenge a united Europe. As the situation unfolds, China and Russia are adopting a new era of global strategic partnership. Where India fits in is the question.

On the sidelines

Prime Minister Narendra Modi's meeting with President Xi on the sidelines of the summit will be critical, especially as Mr. Modi is now being guided by his new External Affairs Minister. This meeting also comes after China's decision to withdraw its technical hold on setting Japan's former chief Masood Adnan as a global secretary at the United Nations Security Council (UNSC). The key concern for the two leaders is the impact of the U.S.-China trade war, but judging from the trends, both sides seem to be gearing up for a big settlement of pending bilateral issues.

Mr. Modi's meeting with Russian President Vladimir Putin is important to save the 3-400 contract deal against Washington's mounting threat to act under CAATSA. India and Russia have an ambitious economic agenda drawn up for 2020, and Mr. Putin might reiterate his invitation to Mr. Modi to be the chief guest at the Eastern Economic Forum in Vladivostok in September. It would be a good opportunity for India to explore Russia's Far East region not just for developing economic cooperation but also for exploring the prospects of transferring skilled labourers to offset Chinese demographic threats in the region. Russia is also keen that India joins the Arctic Territory of Dialogue Forum.

India seems committed to work with the SCO to develop a "cooperative and sustainable security framework", to

make the Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure more effective, and participate in efforts to bring about stability in Afghanistan. Even though the regional aspirations of Central Asian countries contradict India's goals, these countries back India's proposal for a Comprehensive Convention on International Terrorism. Mr. Modi is certain to bring up India's resolve to fight terrorism by drawing the SCO's attention to the attack in Pulwama and the Lakshadweep. But China would not let India to use the SCO to name and shame Pakistan.

India may stick to its position on BRI, but accelerating progress on the International North-South Transport Corridor, the Chabahat Port, the Jalgaon Agreement and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway should be very much on the cards.

The Pakistan policy

The India-Pakistan dilemma endures but the environment has changed a little since India's air strikes in Baluchistan. Pakistan Prime Minister Imran Khan has been less belligerent, but whatever the Pakistanis are taking tougher measures to curb anti-India terror groups is not known. Mr. Khan will have to demonstrate clearly if he means to shift to give diplomacy a chance should they meet on the margins of the SCO meet. Mr. Modi might craft a new policy corner in favour of normalising ties, especially since India has scored a point with Masood Adnan being designated as a global terrorist at the UNSC.

Pakistan places high hopes on the SCO to regulate key regional security issues (Afghanistan and Kashmir) even though the SCO discourages informal disputes to be raised. Its other agenda would be to sell the Gwadar Port as a potential passage to landlocked Central Asian states, besides promoting the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor for regional economic integration and security cooperation.

To be sure, none of the institutional-level measures including the joint SCO military exercises have so far resulted any satisfactory results in jointly fighting against terrorism. Nevertheless, the SCO is relevant for India to garner support for reforms of the UNSC to make the latter more representative and effective. India has been lending support to the member countries' candidatures for non-permanent membership of the UNSC for a long time.

Principal stakeholders are India's Ambassador to the Republic of Kyrgyzstan

What SCO summit means for India's global and regional interests

SHUBHAKTORY
NEW DELHI, JUNE 12

ON THURSDAY, Prime Minister Narendra Modi will travel to the Bishkek capital Bishkek to attend a summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO). Formerly the Shanghai Five and formed in 1996, the SCO has eight members today including India and Pakistan, which became part of it in 2001.

What kind of a grouping is the SCO?

After the collapse of the Soviet Union in 1991, the then security and economic architecture in the Eurasian region dissolved and new structures had to be created. The original Shanghai Five were China, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Russia and Tajikistan. The SCO was formed in 2001, with Uzbekistan included. It expanded in 2017 to include India and Pakistan.

Now it formalises the SCO that focuses

on regional non-traditional security, with counter-terrorism as a priority. The fight against the "three evils" of terrorism, separatism and extremism has become its mantra. Key areas of cooperation include terrorism, counter-terrorism and culture.

Under what circumstances did India enter the SCO?

While Central Asian countries and China were not in favour of expansion initially, the main support — India's entry — particular — was Russia. A widely held view is that Russia's growing concern about an increasingly powerful China prompted it to push for its expansion. From 2009 onwards, Russia officially supported India's ambition to join the SCO. China then asked for its all-weather friend Pakistan's entry.

New Delhi expressed its serious interest to join the grouping in 2008. Months after the Mumbai terror attack in November 2008, Prime Ministers Manmohan Singh and Hu Jintao had their first meeting

in Shanghai in June 2009. The occasion was the annual summit of the SCO, where both India and Pakistan were "observers". The highlight was Singh's message to Zardari: "I am happy to meet you, but my condition is to tell you that the territory of Pakistan must not be used for terrorism." It was the first time India had shown an interest in joining the SCO. Two years of efforts, guided by then Joint Secretary (Eurasia) Ajay Sharma, who is currently India's High Commissioner to Pakistan, resulted in June 2017 when the SCO inducted both India and Pakistan as full members in Kazakhstan.

How does membership of the SCO help India?

For India, two important objectives are counter-terrorism and connectivity. These fit with the SCO's main objective of working cooperatively against the "three evils". India wants access to intelligence and information from SCO's counter-terrorism



The summit provides Indian and Pakistan leaders an opportunity to meet informally.

body, the Turkmen-based Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure (RATS). A stable Afghanistan too is in India's interest, and RATS provides access to Pakistan's counter-terrorism information flows.

Connectivity is important for India's Connect Central Asia policy. Energy cooperation dominates its interest — and it's in China's neighbourhood. But India will also

have to deal with an assertive China, which will push its Belt and Road Initiative during the summit.

SCO membership also bolsters India's status as a major pan-Asian player, which is based on the South Asian pact.

How does global geopolitics play out for SCO and India?

The US power struggle with China, not from the US nuclear deal (JCPOA) affects India's oil imports from Iran, and also an anti-American Russia. After India's \$100 billion purchase of S-400, it has forced India to choose sides. While Washington's stance against Islamabad after the Pulwama attack was evidence of its support to New Delhi, India has had a strained relationship with China after the Chinese stand-off, followed by attempts to normalise relations in Wuhan.

In the SCO, India's strong down with less-than-five members, Russia and China has always had the West worried. India, however, has always been tactful in not

aligning with these countries on its major issues. What draws India to it is the "Shanghai spirit", which emphasises harmony, non-interference in others' internal affairs, and non-alignment.

The bottomline is that it helps India all options open in terms of bilateral partnerships.

How does it play out for the India-Pakistan or India-China relationship?

In the absence of the SAARC summit, SCO summit gives an opportunity for India and Pakistan leaders to meet informal the sidelines. Both sides have the obligation to bring in bilateral disputes, but a common sense of mutual interest as partners signing off on joint counter-terrorism exercises will be a new but engagement between the two militaries. With China, it is yet another open like the BRICS summit last year, to b down tensions, and ahead of the next summit in October in India.



The Indian EXPRESS
JOURNALISM OF COURAGE

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UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II ... International Relations

Bilateral, regional and global groupings and agreements involving India and/or affecting India's interests.

DRAFT QUESTION

Examine how the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation mechanism will benefit India. Critically analyze various contradictions India face, when seen in the perspective of two decades of its foreign policy.

THE HINDU
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The regional aspirations of Central Asian countries contradict India's goals

At the 19th Shanghai Cooperation Organization (SCO) summit in Bishkek, Kyrgyzstan, India will have to navigate between two contradictory imperatives. While on the one hand it must act as a willing partner of regional cooperation led by China and Russia, on the other it must avoid being seen as a part of the 'anti-American gang'. It could also be seen as a paradox that India wants to fight against terrorism through a body that includes states that pose the biggest threats to Indian security.

Trade and terrorism

In Bishkek, Russia and Central Asian countries are likely to express "broad support" for China in its escalating tariff fight against the U.S. India is equally concerned about this trade war, but it is unclear whether it will join the others in slamming U.S. protectionism. New Delhi is seemingly confident of dealing with the U.S. without necessarily supporting China. For Chinese President Xi Jinping, whipping up anti-Americanism serves to stave off mounting opposition against his anti-corruption campaign and concentration of power. It is also notable that all SCO members barring India are enthusiastic supporters of the Belt and Road Initiative (BRI). The summit is likely to have a muted agenda. SCO Secretary General Vladimir Norov has hinted at adopting documents to deepen multilateral cooperation and discussing non-conventional issues such as the fight against drug trafficking, cooperation in IT, environmental protection and healthcare. Terrorism is likely to be approached from the angle of improving the situation in Afghanistan and not necessarily of curbing the terrorist elements emanating from Pakistan. China is sure to offer its experiences of dealing with counterterrorism, and the deradicalisation measures it has taken in Xinjiang. China's achievement in expanding its high-speed rail network to restive Xinjiang comes with enormous economic and security implications for Eurasia. China has also enhanced its military projection capabilities to meet any potential crises beyond its western frontiers:...

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7 Navigations in Bishkek

Kyrgyzstan is the latest to create an international near-border trade centre in Alai district bordering China. If the regional countries switch to adopting the Chinese railway track gauge of 1,435 mm, then China will be successful in uniting Eurasia to challenge a united Europe. As the situation unfolds, China and Russia are adopting a new era of global strategic partnership. Where India fits in is the question.

On the sidelines

Prime Minister Narendra Modi's meeting with President Xi on the sidelines of the summit will be critical, especially as Mr. Modi is now being guided by his new External Affairs Minister. This meeting also comes after China's decision to withdraw its technical hold on listing Jaish-e-Mohammad chief Masood Azhar as a global terrorist at the United Nations Security Council (UNSC). The key concern for the two leaders is the impact of the U.S.-China trade war, but judging from the trends, both sides seem to be gearing up for a big settlement of pending bilateral issues. Mr. Modi's meeting with Russian President Vladimir Putin is important to save the S-400 contract deal against Washington's mounting threat to act under CAATSA. India and Russia have an ambitious economic agenda drawn up for 2019, and Mr. Putin might reiterate his invitation to Mr. Modi to be the chief guest at the Eastern Economic Forum in Vladivostok in September. It would be a good opportunity for India to explore Russia's Far East region not just for developing economic cooperation but also for exploring the prospects of transferring skilled labourers to offset Chinese demographic threats in the region. Russia is also keen that India joins the Arctic: Territory of Dialogue Forum.

7 Navigations in Bishkek

India seems committed to work within the SCO to develop a 'cooperative and sustainable security' framework, to make the Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure more effective, and participate in efforts to bring about stability in Afghanistan. Even though the regional aspirations of Central Asian countries contradict India's goals, these countries back India's proposal for a Comprehensive Convention on International Terrorism. Mr. Modi is certain to bring up India's resolve to fight terrorism by drawing the SCO's attention to the attacks in Pulwama and Sri Lanka. But China would not like India to use the SCO to name and shame Pakistan.

India may stick to its position on BRI, but accelerating progress on the International North-South Transport Corridor, the Chabahar Port, the Ashgabat Agreement and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway should be very much on the cards.

The Pakistan policy

The India-Pakistan stalemate endures but the environment has changed a little since India's air strikes in Balakot. Pakistan Prime Minister Imran Khan has been less belligerent, but whether the Pakistani military is taking tougher measures to curb anti-India terror groups is not known. Mr. Khan will have to demonstrate clearly if he wants Mr. Modi to give diplomacy a chance should they meet on the margins of the SCO meet. Mr. Modi might chart a new policy course in favour of normalising ties, especially since India has scored a point with Masood Azhar being designated as a global terrorist at the UNSC.

Pakistan places high hopes on the SCO to regulate key regional security issues (Afghanistan and Kashmir) even though the SCO discourages bilateral disputes to be raised. Its other agenda would be to sell the Gwadar Port as a potential passage to landlocked Central Asian states, besides promoting the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor for regional economic integration and security cooperation.

7 Navigations in Bishkek

To be sure, none of the institutional-level measures including the joint SCO military exercises have so far entailed any satisfactory results in jointly fighting against terrorism. Nevertheless, the SCO is relevant for India to garner support for reforms of the UNSC to make the latter more representative and effective. India has been lending support to the member countries' candidatures for non-permanent membership of the UNSC for a long time.

Phunchok Stobdan served as India's Ambassador to the Republic of Kyrgyzstan

7 What SCO summit means for India's global and regional interests

Since its formation, the SCO has focused on regional non-traditional security, with counter-terrorism as a priority: The fight against the “three evils” of terrorism, separatism and extremism has become its mantra.

On Thursday, Prime Minister Narendra Modi will travel to the Kyrgyz capital Bishkek to attend a summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO). Formerly the Shanghai Five and formed in 1996, the SCO has eight members today including India and Pakistan, which became part of it in 2017.

What kind of a grouping is the SCO?

After the collapse of the Soviet Union in 1991, the then security and economic architecture in the Eurasian region dissolved and new structures had to come up. The original Shanghai Five were China, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Russia and Tajikistan. The SCO was formed in 2001, with Uzbekistan included. It expanded in 2017 to include India and Pakistan. Since its formation, the SCO has focused on regional non-traditional security, with counter-terrorism as a priority: The fight against the “three evils” of terrorism, separatism and extremism has become its mantra. Today, areas of cooperation include themes such as economics and culture.

Under what circumstances did India enter the SCO?

While Central Asian countries and China were not in favour of expansion initially, the main supporter — of India's entry in particular — was Russia. A widely held view is that Russia's growing unease about an increasingly powerful China prompted it to push for its expansion. From 2009 onwards, Russia officially supported India's ambition to join the SCO. China then asked for its all-weather friend Pakistan's entry.

7 What SCO summit means for India's global and regional interests

New Delhi expressed its serious interest to join the grouping in 2009. Months after the Mumbai terror attacks in November 2008, Prime Ministers Manmohan Singh and Asif Ali Zardari had their first meeting in Ekaterinberg in Russia in June 2009. The occasion was the annual summit of the SCO, where both India and Pakistan were “observers”. The highlight was Singh’s message to Zardari: “I am happy to meet you, but my mandate is to tell you that the territory of Pakistan must not be used for terrorism.”

It was the first time India had shown an interest in joining the SCO. Ten years of efforts, pushed by then Joint Secretary (Eurasia) Ajay Bisaria, who is currently India’s High Commissioner to Pakistan, fructified in June 2017, when the SCO inducted both India and Pakistan in Astana in Kazakhstan.

How does membership of the SCO help India?

For India, two important objectives are counter-terrorism and connectivity. These sit well with the SCO’s main objective of working cooperatively against the “three evils”. India wants access to intelligence and information from SCO’s counter-terrorism body, the Tashkent-based Regional Anti Terror Structure (RATS). A stable Afghanistan too is in India’s interest, and RATS provides access to non-Pakistan-centred counter-terrorism information there.

Connectivity is important for India’s Connect Central Asia policy. Energy cooperation dominates its interest – and it’s in China’s neighbourhood. But India will also have to deal with an assertive China, which will push its Belt and Road Initiative during the summit.

SCO membership also bolsters India’s status as a major pan-Asian player, which is boxed in the South Asian paradigm.

7 What SCO summit means for India's global and regional interests

How does global geopolitics play out for SCO and India?

The US' power struggle with China, exit from the Iran nuclear deal JCPOA (affects India's oil imports from Iran), and adversarial attitude towards Russia (affects India's defence purchase like S-400) have forced India to choose sides. While Washington's stance against Islamabad after the Pulwama attack was evidence of its support to New Delhi, India has had a strained relationship with China after the Doklam stand-off, followed by attempts to reset relations in Wuhan.

In the SCO, India's sitting down with less-than-free regimes, Russia and China has always had the West worried. India, however, has always been tactful in not aligning with these countries on governance issues. What draws India to SCO is the "Shanghai spirit", which emphasises harmony, non-interference in others' internal affairs, and non-alignment. The bottomline is that it helps India keep all options open in terms of international partnerships.

How does it play out in the India-Pakistan or India-China relationship?

In the absence of the SAARC summit, the SCO summit gives an opportunity for Indian and Pakistani leaders to meet informally, on the sidelines. Both sides have the obligation not to bring in bilateral disputes, but can cooperate on issues of mutual interest and importance. Signing off on joint counter-terrorism exercises will be a new form of engagement between the two militaries. With China, it is yet another opening, like the BRICS summit last year, to bring down tensions, and ahead of the next informal summit in October in India.

- SCO Summit is being held in Kyrgyz capital Bishkek.
- It was formerly Shanghai Five formed in 1996.
- This is the entity, which came up after the collapse of Soviet Union in 1991.
- The original Shanghai Five were China, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Russia and Tajikistan.
- SCO was formed in 2001 by including Uzbekistan.
- It expanded in 2017 to include India and Pakistan.



SHANGHAI COOPERATION ORGANISATION (SCO)



SCO is a Eurasian political, economic and military organisation for making joint efforts to maintain and ensure peace, security and stability in the region.

SHANGHAI COOPERATION ORGANIZATION

- It is a permanent inter-governmental international organisation formed in 2001.
- It is established to ensure greater Coordination among the major powers in the Eurasian Region.
- It was preceded by the Shanghai Five Mechanism.
- The SCO's official languages are Russian and Chinese.
- The Heads of State Council (HSC) is the supreme decision-making body in the SCO and it meets once a year.
- SCO comprises Eight Member States i.e., India, Kazakhstan, China, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan.



All the Member States will participate in a joint counter-terrorism exercise, Sary-Arka-Antiterror, 2019.

REGIONAL ANTI-TERRORIST STRUCTURE (RATS)

- RATS is a permanent organ, which serves to promote cooperation of Member States against three evils of terrorism, separatism and extremism.
- The Executive Committee of the Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure (RATS) is based in Tashkent.
- The SCO Secretary-General and the Director of the Executive Committee of the SCO RATS are appointed by the Council of Heads of State for a term of three years.

FOR WHAT IT IS INTENDED?

- Its priority is counter-terrorism.
- It fights against three evils of terrorism, separatism, extremism.
- Today, the areas of cooperation include economics and culture also.



HOW INDIA AND PAKISTAN JOINED?

- In 2009, India has shown interest to join the formation, Russia pushed for it so as to contain increasingly powerful China.
- China batted for Pakistan, finally India and Pakistan became members in 2017.



TWO IMPORTANT OBJECTIVES FOR INDIA

COUNTER-TERRORISM

- It sits well into the objective of fighting three evils of terrorism, separatism and extremism.
- India wants access to intelligence and information from SCO's counter-terrorism body i.e. Tashkent-based Regional Anti Terrorist Structure (RATS).
- A stable Afghanistan is also in India's interest and RATS provides access to non-Pakistan centered counter-terrorism information.

CONNECTIVITY

- It is important for India's Connect Central Asia policy.
- Energy cooperation dominates its interest.
- Central Asia is in the China's neighborhood.



SCO's membership also bolsters India's status as a major pan-Asian player.

INDIA'S DILEMMA

- i. USA exit from Iran Nuclear Deal i.e., JCPOA, affects India's oil imports from Iran.
- ii. Adversarial attitude towards Russia affects India's defence purchases like S-400 defence missile system.



Such issues give rise to India's foreign policy challenges.

COMFORT WITH SCO !

- i. India is in comfort with Shanghai spirit.
- ii. It emphasises harmony, non-interference in others internal affairs and non-alignment.
- iii. Hence, it helps India keep all options open in terms of international partnerships.



OPPORTUNITY FOR INFORMAL PARLEYS BETWEEN INDIA & PAKISTAN



- 1 Now SAARC is dormant. SCO Summit gives an opportunity for Indian and Pakistani leaders to meet informally.
- 2 Both the sides have the obligation not to bring in bilateral disputes. But, can cooperate on issues of mutual interest and importance.
- 3 Working in joint counter terrorism exercises will be a new form of engagement between the two militaries.

INDIA, SCO AND VARIOUS CONTRADICTIONS!

1 The real challenge is to act as a willing partner of regional cooperation led by China and Russia. At the same time, avoiding it to be seen as a part of the Anti American Front is important.



2 It is a paradox that India wants to fight against terrorism through the body that includes Pakistan, which is the biggest threat to Indian security.



INDIA, SCO AND VARIOUS CONTRADICTIONS!

3 China is extremely unhappy with the escalating tariff fight against the US. Though India is equally concerned, but India is confident of dealing with US, without necessarily supporting China.



4 All SCO members, barring India are enthusiastic supporters of the Belt and Road Initiative (BRI).



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